

type of documents will be printed and make sure the printer can accommodate the paper size that will be used. The printer's maximum paper width can be a limiting factor if not planned ahead.

Inkjets are the choice for printing photos. Photos printed on the colour lasers are inferior to those printed on inkjet printers. Lasers are best at printing black text. The quality is topnotch, and they are fast and the cost per page is low. Photos from colour lasers and inkjets were closer in quality on plain paper than on their manufacturers' best photo paper. A colour laser with a high rating in that mode may be a good choice for those who plan to print photos only on plain paper and also want the speed advantage of a colour laser in printing colour graphics.

All-in-one inkjets are the best all-purpose printers for those who want to print both text and colour photos, and be able to scan and copy. Most have

memory card slots and PictBridge. Some can fax documents. The recent trend for regular inkjet printers is to be basic printers with few extra features.

Wide-format printers are for those who want to print very large photos, signs or posters. The wide-format HP Officejet 7500A can also scan and copy A3 size. A serious photographer might like the Epson R2880 or the Canon PIXMA 9000 Mark II. Both hold eight inks and can print photos up to A3+ size. The Epson printer also has a ninth ink for black matte photo printing (it replaces the regular black ink) and can print on roll photo paper. But it didn't do well in non-photo printing tasks.

A low print speed can slow down your productivity. This can be a very important feature if you are planning to use the printer in an office environment. Generally, more expensive printers are much faster than lower priced models. Keep in mind that when printing in colour, print speed will be significantly reduced.

Consider print quality next. View actual print samples, if possible. For consumer-level photo output, seek minimum 1200-dpi resolution and six colours.

Then check versatility, cost-per-page, consumable costs, image longevity and paper-handling options. This will allow you to assess the hidden and collateral costs that come with operating a printer.

Paying more for a printer doesn't necessarily mean you'll get better prints. Don't consider only the purchase price of the printer. Per-print costs can make a cheaper model more expensive in the long run than a higher-priced printer with low per-copy costs.

In overall performance, Dell 2155cn followed by Canon iP4850 and HP Officejet Pro 8500A Plus e-AIO A910 printers performed best. ●

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